Soon afterwards, I am asked to take the wicketkeeping gloves, so Mark Boucher can have a chance to bowl and, annoyingly, he claims the wicket of Bravo, caught by Ashwell Prince for 107. It must be rare for a wicketkeeper to bowl and take a Test wicket, but in this Test two wicketkeepers bowl and both take wickets.

But as the roller-coaster soars, so the roller-coaster dips …

In and out of the ODI side, selected one week, left out the next, selected again, I get a few starts in the one-day international series against the West Indies, then playing for an Africa XI against an Asia XI, then in a home series against New Zealand, and then on a short tour to India, but I can't get past 39 in nine innings and I'm almost relieved when, in December, we revert to playing five-day Test cricket on tour in Australia.

The Aussies are a powerful team that includes Justin Langer, Matthew Hayden, Ricky Ponting, Mike Hussey, Adam Gilchrist, Shane Warne, Brett Lee and Glenn McGrath, but we hold our own in the first Test in Perth. I feel in decent form and reach 68 in our first innings before being bowled by a straight ball from Warne. We battle hard through five days and Jacques Rudolph's unbeaten century secures a creditable draw.

Moving on to Melbourne, we prepare for the Test at the MCG starting on Boxing Day.

The Australians bat first and two of their stars score centuries in the first innings. This is a tough and relentless contest, although the renowned sledging of the Australians seems relatively mild compared to what I experienced from my older brothers and their friends in our back garden. Yet, amid the hustle and excitement of a full house at the MCG, I remain a largely innocent 21-year-old in awe of our celebrated opponents.

I bump into one of the leading Australian batsmen during the lunch interval.

'Well batted today,' I say instinctively, without really thinking. 'That was a great knock.'